

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS/AI**

online platforms allowing aggrieved citizens to file their complaints. But in a country with a population of 1.4 billion, scanning the large volume of complaints and acting on them is an exercise in futility, given the time it consumes and the lack of manpower. However, the use of AI is not only making the grievance redressal system faster and more accountable, it's also helping government agencies detect systemic flaws and map socio-economic issues in various geographic locations. The most shining example has been the Integrated Grievance Management System (IGMS) developed by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), which Prime Minister Narendra Modi handles directly.



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– V. SRINIVAS
Secretary, DARPG

The use of AI facilitates instant categorisation of complaints, summarisation, and routing to the departments concerned. It can easily do keyword and semantic searches, point out oversight whenever required and display complaints in a dashboard in real time. The IGMS uses the same technology that powers ChatGPT. "The categorisation helps us identify and analyse the policy interventions required if similar complaints keep reappearing. We can also detect if there is inefficiency on the part of any department or officer. Prime Minister Modi is very serious about the effective implementation of this mechanism and often checks the dashboard," says V. Srinivas, Secretary, DARPG.

↘ WHAT INDIA NEEDS TO MASTER

The AI-powered IGMS has been in use for all central government ministries and departments since February 2023. Such initiatives should now spread to all states as well. Digital infrastructure and services are not uniformly spread across all states in India. For instance, if Kerala offers 886 e-services, Rajasthan extends only 248, Bihar 234 and Gujarat 228. Smaller states such as Manipur, Nagaland and Sikkim don't even offer 50 such services. If states such as Andhra Pradesh are using blockchain to map land records, many states have not rolled out even the mandatory 56 digital services. Only 13 states have all 15 mandatory financial services online, while 13 others have the 13 mandatory services related to local governance and utility.

To ensure uniform and efficient services across the country, the government must first strengthen the digital infrastructure. On August 6, the Union cabinet approved Rs 1.39 lakh crore for BharatNet Project, its flagship project to enhance rural internet connectivity. The next important step will be to ensure that all Common Services Centres (CSC) remain functional throughout the year. In most remote areas, people cannot access these facilities because of lack of manpower and poor infrastructure.

Another key component in the efficient functioning of e-government services is trained manpower to handle these utilities. In several states, government officials are either not trained to use these digital innovations effectively or the frequency of training does not keep up with the speed of technological evolutions impacting these services. That's why the government built a trained human resource for last-mile delivery of digital services. The Centre has made it mandatory that every officer must undergo 50 hours of training on emerging technologies. States also must follow suit. ■